

Choosing plants for sun or shade

Some plants like it hot while others shy away from the sun, but whatever the conditions found in your plot, there's a wealth of beautiful plants to choose from to create a visual feast. The key is to match the plants to environmental conditions.

SUN-LOVING PLANTS

Dry dusty soil and blazing hot sun are challenging conditions for plant growth, and species unsuited to such sites will soon suffer. However, some of the most beautiful plants and flowers have adapted to thrive in these areas, including a whole host of colorful blooms, and sculptural shrubs and trees you can use even if your soil is sandy and your yard or garden faces south.

A plant's label will usually tell you the conditions it prefers, but you can often tell when plants are suited to hot, dry sites because many share key characteristics that help them survive.

These include small leaves to reduce moisture loss, silvery foliage to reflect light, and hairs that store water droplets, protecting the surface from the sun and reducing evaporation. Succulents have fleshy stems and leaves that store water, while other sun-lovers have colorful flowers that shine in strong light, attracting pollinating insects. Use these visual clues, along with the plant labels, to identify plants best suited to your site.

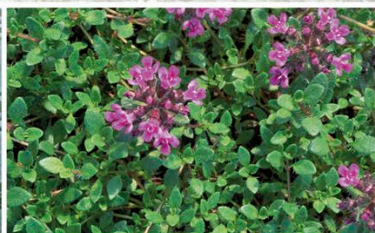
Soaking up the rays These sun-loving specimens show the range of beautiful plants that can cope with strong light.



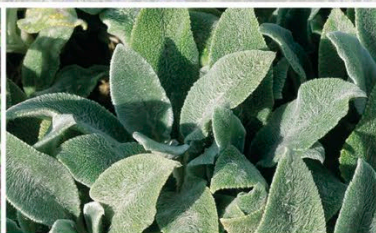
KEY CHARACTERISTICS OF SUN-LOVING PLANTS



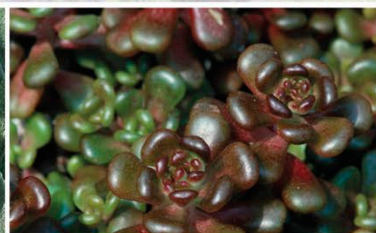
Silver foliage Most plants with reflective silver leaves enjoy hot sites and shimmer in strong light.



Small leaves A reduced surface area helps foliage to minimize moisture loss during transpiration.



Furry foliage Hairy leaves trap moisture, helping to sustain plants during drought.



Fleshy stems and leaves Some plants from dry regions trap moisture in their leaves and stems.